

Rep. Tom Emmer on America Reports

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SANDRA:

Congressman, welcome to you. I think people are going to be shocked and stunned to find out just how much money is being put in the hands of other people, our hard-earned taxpayer dollars. What does this report reveal?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, great to be with you, Sandra. And yes, you're right. It reveals that almost \$200 billion in overpayments were made last year under several different government programs. Over 50% of them are Medicare, Medicaid, and the SNAP program. Sandra, we've done an amazing job in Congress, especially with the big, beautiful tax cut bill that was signed into law about a year ago, and putting new restrictions, new surveillance-type requirements. For instance, illegals can no longer access Medicaid. Huge savings. But we've got a long way to go, as this GAO report that was just released shows us. This overpayments, in spite of those reforms that were done a year ago, are \$24 billion higher than the year before, Sandra. We've got a lot of work to do.

JOHN:

As much as \$3 trillion, apparently, according to this report, has been lost to overpayments since fiscal year 2003. That's just insanity. And I want to put up this pie chart that was included in the GAO report showing where these payments are going. 82% of them are going to overpayments. But look at this. \$14.3 billion went to unknown payments. How do you spend \$14 billion on stuff you don't even know you're spending it on?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, John, unfortunately, my state, the great state of Minnesota, is ground zero for this kind of nonsense. It seems like a Somali fraudster is getting convicted every week on fraud. So it's not just quote-unquote overpayments. It's people who have figured out how to game the system. And you don't have the review, the oversight in place at the state level to make sure that these payments are getting to the people that they're intended for. The poor, the single mothers with children, the disabled, the seniors. Instead, you've got fraudsters that are taking us to the wall every single day. So when they say overpayments, John, and when you talk about these unknowns, the overpayments they can talk about the actual program. But where does the other \$14 billion go? Like I said, we've got a lot of work left to do. And I think, John, the quote that you both played at the beginning of this segment, very clear. These aren't just outdated systems. Some of these systems go back to the 1970s, John and Sandra. They're not just not talking to each other. They aren't up to the task. So there's a lot of work left to be done to go after the waste, fraud, and abuse. Unfortunately, my state is ground zero for this sort of thing, and we're going to have to make sure we do a much better job.

SANDRA:

Well, Congressman, before another cent is paid out, we've got to make sure that our hard-earned taxpayer dollars are ending up in the wrong hands. What's what's the plan?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, I think you saw the plan. One, Doge, when President Trump took office, was a necessary entity to start exposing all of this and going after it. I don't think the American public, Sandra, understood just how serious that is. This is they hear numbers, but it's just like my state. I don't think my state realized we were talking about nine billion dollars or more that had been stolen under the Tim Walz administration. Now people in Minnesota are waking up because this isn't about a Republican Democrat thing. This is about a Minnesota. This is about an American thing. We believe in fairness and fairness isn't about feeding the fraudsters. This is about making sure that those seniors that need the benefits that we've created get them, that the single moms get the benefits that they're entitled to and disabled Americans, etc. This is a huge deal, as John pointed out. Just the overpayment piece. Keep in mind, this is just the overpayment piece is estimated to be some three trillion dollars since 2003.

JOHN:

Yeah. Again, as we said, that's just insane. If there is any kind of a silver lining here, it's that the number of overpayments are going down. In recent fiscal years, twenty twenty one was the high watermark, two hundred and one point four billion dollars in improper payments. It's now one eighty five point eight dip to a low one sixty one point five in twenty twenty four. But still, I mean, that's crazy money that's going out the door. Final word to you, Congressman.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, again, Sandra, what's the next step? Perhaps when we're talking twenty twenty one, twenty twenty two people in the Biden administration and people that were bilking the Biden administration realized what was coming. Donald J. Trump and the Republicans. The first step you saw a year ago, John, the next step, Sandra, is going to be making sure that we make these requirements, these screening tools even more significant. That's going to be the key. You've got to make sure that what's in place for oversight guarantees that these taxpayer dollars are going to exactly what they were intended and not to the the fraudsters like the Somali fraudsters in Minnesota.

SANDRA:

All right. Congressman Tom Emmer. Always appreciate your time, sir. Thanks for joining us.

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